

◀ BEFORE

The negative press of the Tet Offensive gave Johnson a reason to once again seek conciliation.

RELUCTANT WARMONGER

Johnson began escalation of the war in Vietnam in 1964 following the **Tonkin Gulf Resolution**, but would rather have focused on domestic policy. After the 1968 **Tet Offensive**, the president was haunted by the seemingly futile war effort and sinking public approval.



PRESIDENT JOHNSON MEETS A US SOLDIER

On the evening of March 31, 1968, President Johnson delivered a televised address to the American nation from the White House, during which he surprisingly announced a partial halt to the US bombing of North Vietnam—an olive branch that he hoped would lead to peace negotiations with Hanoi and a rapid de-escalation of the conflict. While Johnson had attempted in 1965 and again in 1967 to halt the bombings and appeal for peace talks, these earlier overtures had failed to lead to a resolution. Now, the president tried once more.

"Our purpose in this action," said Johnson, "is to bring about a reduction in the level of violence that now exists. It is to save the lives of brave men—and to save the lives of innocent women and children. It is to permit the contending forces to move closer to a political settlement."

The address was a remarkable (if perhaps unintentional) admission on Johnson's part, acknowledging that the NVA's Tet Offensive—despite failing to achieve its military objectives and largely neutralizing the Viet Cong as a fighting force—had achieved its major political aim. In the eight weeks since the offensive, the US media had turned against the war. By extension, so had US public opinion. Rather than extend a war that seemed unwinnable, Johnson pushed for peace.

Common ground